

Organizational nationalism

Lori Qingyuan Yue^{a,*}, Yusaku Takeda^{b,1}^a Columbia Business School, United States^b University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, United States

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ABSTRACT

The global rise of nationalism has distorted the neoliberal vision of a borderless world where the nationality of businesses would be rendered obsolete. While nationalism can promote social solidarity and progress, it also has the potential to deepen divisions and fuel conflict—realities that organizations cannot ignore. In this paper, we propose a theory of *organizational nationalism*, which positions organizations not merely as passive responders to nationalist institutional pressures or geopolitical risks but as active agents in shaping nationalistic beliefs, values, and policies. Through theorizing how organizational nationalism manifests and functions, we offer insights into how organizations harness nationalism to motivate employees, cultivate consumer loyalty, and secure sociopolitical legitimacy, and how such engagement may eventually become an organizational commitment that shapes its nationalist character. This perspective fills a critical void in nationalism research by emphasizing the intermediary role played by organizations between the state and individual levels of nationalism. It also offers a unifying framework for the fragmented literature on nationalism in business, which spans topics from state influence on organizational forms to managing “foreignness” in multinational corporations. We conclude by outlining a research roadmap and promising research methodologies in this area.

Introduction

For decades, scholars have predicted that globalization would erode the power of the nation-state, resulting in a world dominated by large, stateless corporations (Chandler & Mazlish, 2005; Dunning & Lundan, 2008; Reich, 1990; Strange, 1996). In this vision of a “borderless world,” national borders and identities would become increasingly irrelevant for businesses, supplanted by neoliberal market logics and the unbounded mobility of capital. Firms were expected to shed their national ties, aligning instead with global efficiency, competitiveness, and shareholder value, and “corporate nationality” (Reich, 1990) would become largely obsolete.

Yet today’s reality paints a sharply different picture. Across many societies, nationalist movements have reasserted the primacy of the nation, reviving concerns over sovereignty, cultural identity, and economic self-determination. Global challenges—from pandemics and climate change to resource scarcity and geopolitical tensions—are increasingly framed in national terms, demanding solutions that are domestically focused. These developments cast doubt on the once-assured narrative of globalization’s triumph, instead accentuating the

enduring—and resurgent—power of nationalism. As critics have observed, “For the foreseeable future, nationalism is likely to remain a defining political force” (Mounk, 2018), binding people through narratives of belonging and allegiance to national interests.

Against this backdrop, firms have begun to nurture nationalism, not as an external constraint but as an active expression of organizational values and strategies. More organizations invoke national identity to galvanize employees, connect with consumers, and build legitimacy (Castelló & Mihelj, 2018). This trend is apparent across different national contexts: the use of nationalist rhetoric by Chinese public firms, for instance, nearly doubled from 2000 to 2020 (Yue, Zheng, & Mao, 2024), while in the United States, research has documented firms employing patriotic rhetoric, adopting nation-themed branding, and aligning with the national political climate (Benos & Jochev, 2012; Bonaparte, Kumar, & Page, 2017; Mohr & Schumacher, 2019; Feng & Takeda, 2025). From patriotic marketing campaigns and nation-themed product lines to corporate missions aligned with national priorities—such as technological self-reliance, job creation, or cultural preservation—businesses are re-embedding themselves within nationalistic narratives and practices. What explains this turn toward

* Corresponding author

E-mail address: qy2103@columbia.edu (L.Q. Yue).¹ Equal Contribution.

nationalism? How and why do organizations adopt them? And what are the broader implications when businesses assume an active role in shaping national discourse and identity?

These questions reveal a critical gap in existing research. While nationalism studies have long explored how states cultivate national identities and how individuals internalize them (Anderson, 1983; Hobsbawm & Ranger, 1983; Wimmer, 2023), they have overlooked organizations as mediating agents in this process. Similarly, organizational theory and behavior research have treated nationalism primarily as a contextual variable—manifesting as institutional pressure (e.g., Evans, 1995; Kalev et al., 2008), regulatory risk (e.g., Henisz & Zelner, 2010; Luo, 2022), or political volatility (e.g., Arian & Shenkar, 2013; Bruno, Henisz, & Gracheva, 2025)—rather than as a force organizations can actively nurture. This oversight is striking given that firms possess vast economic and cultural resources, function as primary sites of socialization and employment, and wield influence across multiple levels of society (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983; Dobbin, 1994; Perrow, 1986; Scott, 2014; Selznick, 1952).

In this paper, we address this gap by introducing the concept of *organizational nationalism*—the idea that organizations can adopt, enact, and propagate nationalist values, symbols, and narratives through their discourses, activities, strategies, and interactions with the broader sociopolitical environment. We argue that firms are not merely passive entities shaped by national contexts; they can act as agents of nationalism, shaping identity, mobilizing sentiment, and reshaping the meaning of national belonging. We begin by integrating extensive but disparate research on nationalism in the social sciences and organizational behavior and theory. We propose a conceptual framework that encompasses the content and archetype of organizational nationalism, as well as the intermediary role it plays between state and individual nationalism. As we discuss, we present a research roadmap that addresses key questions and promising methodologies. Together, we offer a new theoretical perspective to understand contemporary corporate behavior and its far-reaching implications for business, society, and the global order.

Existing research on nationalism

Nationalism research in social sciences

Nationalism is commonly described as “an ideology that elevates one nation or nationality above all others and that places primary emphasis on the promotion of culture and interests as opposed to those of other nations, nationalities, or supranational groups” (Merriam-Webster, 2025). Domestically, such an ideology prioritizes the interests of the nation over those of individuals and subgroups; internationally, it favors the interests of one nation over those of others. In this vein, social scientists have posited that viewing nationalism merely as a system of ideas and ideals—an “ideology” in the classical sense—overlooks the deeper source of its profound social influence and resilience (Brubaker, 1996; Freeden, 1998, 2001; Smith, 2010). Pioneering studies in the 1980s—including Gellner’s *Nations and Nationalism* (1983), Anderson’s *Imagined Communities* (1983), Hobsbawm and Ranger’s *The Invention of Tradition* (1983), and Smith’s *National Identity* (1991)—collectively revealed that nationalism is best understood as historically grounded in a shared sense of belonging to a perceived national community, rather than as a coherent belief system that transcends time and place. This contrasts nationalism with many other “isms,” such as liberalism, communism, or socialism, which exhibit more stable belief systems (Freeden, 1998). Searle-White (2001, p. 3) argued, “Nationalism, in its broadest definition, is simply a sense of identification with a group of people who share a common history, language, territory, culture, or some combination of these,” meeting a fundamental human need for social belonging (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989; Morris, 2024). The very notion of “nation,” rooted in the Latin *nasci* (to be born) and *natio* (group bound by birth), is socially constructed and “imagined”

(Anderson, 1983).

A central debate in this tradition concerns whether nationalism is rooted more in enduring ethnic ties (Smith, 1991) or modern civic institutions (Brubaker, 1996; Gellner, 1983). While these perspectives differ, they converge on the idea that individuals are the building blocks of national identity, exploring how this identity is formed, maintained, and transmitted. Across the social sciences—from political science and sociology to social psychology—research on nationalism tends to operate at two primary levels of analysis: the state and the individual.

State-level Perspectives

At the macro level, nationalism is explored as a political force embedded in the historical processes of state formation, colonial legacies, and intergroup conflict (Bendix, 1996; Mylonas, 2012; Wimmer, 2023). Rooted in comparative historical research, this literature builds on foundational theories of state-making (Tilly, 1975, 1990) and examines how governments construct national identity and deploy policies to reinforce national cohesion.

Three research streams are prominent. The first investigates the rise of modern nation-states, attributing their emergence to wars, social contracts, modernization, and global diffusion (e.g., Spruyt, 1994; Wimmer & Min, 2008; Wimmer, 2023; Lawrence, 2013; Beissinger, 2002). The second explores the construction and evolution of national narratives within countries (e.g., Bonikowski, 2016; Tudor & Slater, 2021). The third examines how national narratives influence societal outcomes such as political behavior, institutional trust, and international relations (e.g., Lieberman, 2003; Thies, 2009; Mearsheimer, 2018). However, this body of work rarely considers the role of organizations as agents in shaping, disseminating, or contesting nationalist ideologies.

Individual-level Perspectives

At the micro level, nationalism research focuses on national identity—how individuals internalize, experience, and express their sense of belonging to a national group. Political psychologists have shown that national identity is both cognitive and affective, emerging through attitudes, group affiliations, and symbolic attachments (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989; Li & Brewer, 2004; Searle-White, 2001). National identity fosters a sense of collective recognition and emotional attachment grounded in shared history, cultural traditions, and myths of origin (Searle-White, 2001; Smith, 1991; Morris, 2024).

While the content of national identity varies—emphasizing either ethnic heritage or civic values—it shapes how individuals perceive themselves, relate to others, and define their civic responsibilities. Empirical studies using surveys and experiments have demonstrated how national identity can foster civic engagement (Huddy & Khatib, 2007), bridge sub-national divides (Li & Brewer, 2004), or reduce intragroup bias (by homogenizing the members of the nation) (Transue, 2007; Charnysh et al., 2015). At the same time, when national identity is institutionalized through dominant ethnic narratives, it can lead to decreased tolerance of minorities (Weldon, 2006; Elkins & Sides, 2007) or shunning of foreign products (Shankarmahesh, 2006). Cultural sociologists have further examined the variability of nationalist sentiment across populations and its implications for immigration attitudes and political behavior (Bonikowski & DiMaggio, 2016; Brubaker, 1996).

Across both levels, the role of organizations as intermediaries between the state and individuals remains underexplored. In modern societies, organizations—whether corporations or nonprofits—play a crucial role in shaping identity and behavior, as they provide employment, structure daily life, and wield significant financial, cultural, and political capital. Mechanisms such as corporate lobbying, branding, and internal socialization can act as indirect conduits for state ideology (Dobbin, 1994; Evans, 1995). Moreover, organizations possess the capacity to mobilize resources and influence public discourse across

diverse constituencies (King & Soule, 2007; Scherer & Palazzo, 2011; Yue, 2015). Ignoring such organizational dynamics significantly limits our knowledge of how nationalism functions in society.

Nationalism research in management literature

Research on nationalism at the organizational level—mostly emerging from the management field—remains fragmented and under-theorized. While studies address how nationalism affects for-profit and non-profit organizations, few explicitly recognize nationalism as a distinct social phenomenon in organizational life. Our review identifies two dominant strands: (1) nationalism as state influence on organizations and (2) nationalism as liability of foreignness for multinational enterprises. Table 1 provides an overview of these perspectives and representative studies.

Nationalism as State Influence

Institutional theory has long emphasized how government policies and regulatory environments constrain or enable organizational forms and behaviors (Dobbin, 1994; Evans, 1995; Kalev et al., 2008; Marquis & Raynard, 2015; Zhang, 2022). The state is a source of legitimacy, shaping organizational longevity and success. Firms that align with national priorities—such as technological sovereignty or employment generation—are more likely to receive favorable treatment, including subsidies or access to public procurement (Ingram & Rao, 2004). Conversely, those who deviate may face regulatory hurdles or reputational backlash (Ingram & Simons, 2000). While some organizations may act as partial substitutes for the state (e.g., kibbutzim in Israel), they rarely rival the state's power to define national ideology (Simons & Ingram, 2003). Apart from a few exceptions (Ingram & Inman, 1996), the literature seldom explores how organizations actively co-create, endorse, or contest nationalist agendas.

Nationalism as Liability of Foreignness

In international business (IB) research, nationalism is related to concepts like “liabilities of foreignness.” From an *external* perspective, nationalism has been studied as a geopolitical risk and political hazard (Arikan & Shenkar, 2013; Bucheli, Ciravegna, & Sáenz, 2023; Choudhury, et al., 2025; Ertug, Cuypers, Dow, & Edman, 2024; Luo, 2022; Shi, Hoskisson, & Zhang, 2016). Political events, surges of national pride, or protectionist measures can undermine cross-border operations, escalate costs, and halt expansions (Bruno, Henisz, & Gracheva, 2025; Henisz & Zelner, 2010). While IB research has explored the barriers that nationalism imposes on multinational corporations, it has devoted little attention to the organizational choice to embrace or advocate nationalist stances, particularly in ways beyond risk mitigation.

From an *internal* perspective, IB researchers have examined how host country managers in multinational subsidiaries experience conflicts arising from their dual identities—national and organizational. These identity tensions often lead to personal stress and constitute an internal source of the liability of foreignness (Lee, Kim, & You, 2023). Such managers are described as “foreign locals” (Baikovich & Wasserman, 2020; Caprar, 2011; Koveshnikov, Vaara, & Ehrnrooth, 2016; Ybema & Byun, 2009) or “cultural aliens” (Baikovich & Wasserman, 2020; Brannen & Fruin, 1999; Brannen & Peterson, 2009; Koveshnikov et al., 2016; Ybema & Byun, 2009). While some successfully integrate both identities, others experience acculturative stress. Additionally, nationalism-based exclusion remains prevalent in the workplace (Fiske & Lee, 2008; Klarsfeld, Ng, Booysen, Christiansen, & Kuvaas, 2016), contributing to lower job satisfaction, higher levels of burnout, and increased turnover intentions among foreign nationals (Köllen & Kopf, 2022). Even for local executives working for foreign companies, the occurrence of heightened nationalist events, such as anti-foreign protests, can prompt their departure (Zhang, Lu, & Liu, 2025).

Furthermore, the IB literature often treats nationalism as a *country-level* concept, as if nationalism exists somewhat uniformly at the level of a nation (Arikan & Shenkar, 2013; Dow & Cuypers, 2024; Ertug, Brennecke, Kovács, & Zou, 2021; Li, Shapiro, Ufimtseva, & Zhang, 2024). This approach overlooks the significant organizational heterogeneity in how nationalism is embraced or embodied. Nonetheless, emerging work suggests that certain multinational enterprises may seek to leverage local nationalism—for instance, by highlighting domestic production, employing marketing campaigns attuned to local patriots, or associating themselves with local firms (Mohr & Schumacher, 2019; Xia, Steensma, & Bai, 2023).

Nationalism in Organizational Behavior

Only recently has research begun to explore nationalism as something that organizations themselves can embody and project. A growing yet scattered body of work shows that some firms frame themselves as patriotic entities, using nationalist symbols and narratives to build legitimacy and strengthen stakeholder ties (Foster et al., 2011; Holt, 2006; Lubinski & Wadhvani, 2020; Takeda, 2022; Yue et al., 2024; Yue et al., in press). These studies suggest that nationalism influences organizational decision-making, stakeholder engagement, and strategic communication as a cultural force. Building on these insights, we propose organizational nationalism—the idea that firms can actively adopt, perform, and propagate nationalist ideologies and practices.

Organizational nationalism: a framework

Definition and content of organizational nationalism

We define *organizational nationalism* as an organization's multifaceted efforts to adopt, embody, and promote nationalistic beliefs, symbols, and values, either as a strategic tool or as expressions of its core identity, values, and culture. Our conceptualization builds on Yue, Zheng, and Mao's (2024) four-dimensional framework of collective identification rooted in group-member exchange theory. This theory posits that members derive a sense of security, identity, and self-worth from their affiliation with a group and are expected to reciprocate with loyalty and even sacrifice for the group's interests (Druckman, 1994; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). For organizational nationalism, this “group” is the nation, and the “member” is the organization.

Organizational nationalism manifests in four types of organizational behaviors. First, it encompasses ingroup favoritism, reflected in expressions of *national pride and identification*—organizations may celebrate a nation's history, culture, institutions, or economic, technological, or military achievements. Second, it entails varying degrees of *anti-foreignness*, an outgroup bias wherein foreign entities—people, competitors, governments, or markets—are portrayed as threats to national identity and interests. Third, it involves aligning with *dominant societal agendas* at specific historical junctures, such as responding to trade conflicts, defending sovereignty, or enacting calls for national revitalization. Finally, organizational nationalism emphasizes active participation in national priorities such as producing military or industrial goods of national importance, creating domestic jobs, advancing technological innovation, and preserving cultural heritage. Table 2 categorizes these four dimensions as well as exemplary organizational behaviors. Importantly, not all organizational nationalism encompasses all four types of behavior; organizations may engage in one or more dimensions, depending on their geography, industry, and historical context.

Two functions of organizational nationalism

Organizational nationalism fulfills interconnected functions: *strategic* and *ideological*. In the former, nationalism helps obtain resources, legitimacy, or stakeholder support. In the latter, nationalism manifests

Table 1
Nationalism-related research in organizational behavior and theory.

Nationalism as	Definition	Dominant Focus	Representative Works
State influence	Nationalism as the state's regulatory/ideological influences over organizations, guiding or constraining strategy, structure, and behavior.	- Government policies and domestic political constraints (e.g., industrial policy, protective regulations, local content rules) - Legitimacy gained or lost by aligning with or resisting state guidelines - Resource dependence on state bodies (e.g., licensing, government contracts, subsidies) - Embeddedness: forging or avoiding political ties, lobbying for favorable treatment, or dealing with contested "national security" concerns.	Ault and Spicer (2014) , Bucheli (2005) , Bucheli et al. (2023) , Cohen et al. (2016) , Dobbin (1994) , Duanmu (2014) , Evans (1995) , Greenwood et al. (2010) , Haveman et al. (2017) , Ingram and Rao (2004) , Ingram and Simons (2000) , Inoue et al. (2013) , Kriauciunas and Kale (2006) , Lazzarini (2015) , Li et al. (2018) , Liang et al. (2015) , Marquis and Raynard (2015) , Marquis and Qiao, (2020, 2022) , Matten and Crane (2005) , Milberg et al. (2000) , Murtha and Lenway (1994) , Ralston et al. (2006) , Schuler et al. (2002) , Schneider and De Meyer (1991) , Wang et al. (2018) , Zhang (2022) , Zhang et al. (2016) , Zhou et al. (2017) .
Liability of foreignness	Nationalism as the source of "liability of foreignness," shaped by host-country animosity, trade barriers, cultural distance and political interventions that affect international transactions.	- Trade disputes, tariffs, or historical animosity - Cross-border M&A risk: government blocks deals, regulates ownership - National security rhetoric ("foreign competitor as threat") - Non-market strategies to navigate these risks: lobbying, alliances, or local partnerships - Dual identity conflicts, mistrust of foreign investors, and consumer boycotts driven by national identity	Alvarez and Rangan (2019) , Arikan and Shenkar (2013) , Arikan et al. (2020) , Bailey and Spicer (2007) , Bertrand et al. (2016) , Bucheli et al. (2023) , Canayaz and Darendeli (2024) , Casadei and Iammarino (2021) , Choudhury et al. (2025) , Ciravegna and Michailova (2021) , Click and Weiner (2010) , Contractor (2021) , Edman et al. (2024) , Ertug et al. (2024) , Evenett (2019) , Gardberg and Fombrun (2006) , Kobrin (2017) , Godsell et al. (2023) , Henisz and Zelner (2010) , Hitt et al. (2006) , Melewar and Saunders (1999) , Meyer and Altenborg (2008) , Mithani (2024) , Li et al. (2024) , Lubinski and Wadhwani (2020) , Luo (2022) , Luo and Van Assche (2023) , Petricevic and Teece (2019) , Salk & Shenkar (2001) , Shi et al. (2016) , Stevens et al. (2016) , Tian et al. (in press) , Vaaler (2008) , Vaara and Tienari (2011) , Xia et al. (2023) , Yiu et al. (2022) .
Organizational nationalism	Nationalism as the strategic or ideological discourses and actions by the organizations—where firms incorporate patriotic symbols, rhetoric, and a national identity into their strategic and cultural practices.	- Patriotic branding: "Made in [Country]," appealing to local consumer pride - National identity woven into mission & communications—organization as a "citizen" championing national goal - Mobilizing domestic stakeholders: emphasizing local heritage to gain subsidies, consumer loyalty, or government protection - Endorsing nationalistic movement	Balabanis et al. (2001) , Mohr and Schumacher (2019) , Sadeh and Zilber (2019) , Sharma et al. (1994) , Takeda (2022) , Yue et al. (2024) , Yue et al. (in press) .

Table 2
Four-Dimensional Conceptualization of Organizational Nationalism.

Group-Member Exchange	OGN Dimensions	Exemplary Organizational Behaviors
Group Identification: members derive a sense of security, identity, and self-worth from their affiliation with a group	National Pride and Identification: organizations demonstrate ingroup favoritism	• Expressing alignment with the national spirit, value, and character • Proud of being a member of a country, or Made-In-Country • Pride in a nation's history, cultural heritage, institutions, or achievements
	Anti-Foreignness: organizations demonstrate outgroup bias	• Negatively portraying foreign entities • Viewing foreign entities as threats to national identity and interests • Advocating for protectionist policies • Express Chauvinism and view a nation's culture and institutions as superior to those of others
Member Reciprocation: members are expected to reciprocate with loyalty and even sacrifice for the group's interests	Dominant Societal Agenda: organizations emphasize prevailing national narratives and priorities during a specific historical moment	Organizations reflect government policies, public opinion, and grassroots mobilization related to societal tasks such as: • Resisting foreign intrusion, defending national sovereignty and homeland security • Navigating trade conflicts or territorial disputes • National rejuvenization • Relieving from natural disaster or public health crisis
	Organization's Active Role: organizations contribute to urgent national priorities and general national interests through their own operations	• Producing military equipment • Stimulating economic growth • Creating employment opportunities • Hiring veterans • Fostering national leadership in technology and innovation • Investing in infrastructure • Preserving national culture and history

in beliefs and values embedded in organizational institutions and priorities. These two functions can coexist and form four organizational nationalism archetypes.

Strategic function

Organizations may employ nationalist themes to build relationships with government actors, attract patriotic consumers, or appeal to domestic investors. Nationalist positioning can facilitate access to subsidies, public contracts, and increased legitimacy, particularly in environments where the state presents itself as the guardian of national welfare (Mohr & Schumacher, 2019). Strategic nationalism also appeals to non-state stakeholders. For instance, firms may engage in consumer nationalism—e.g., through “Buy American” campaigns—to reframe local production as a symbol of resilience and pride (Holt, 2006; Castelló

& Mihelj, 2018). Research shows that consumer-facing businesses (To-C) are more likely to adopt nationalist messaging than business-to-business (To-B) counterparts (Yue et al., 2024). Similarly, public alignment with nationalist ideals has been shown to attract increased investment attention (Bonaparte et al., 2017). A strategic use of nationalism also carries reputational risk. Stakeholders may challenge the authenticity of nationalist rhetoric, viewing it as opportunistic branding (Foster et al., 2011; Holt, 2006). Stakeholders often judge authenticity by tracing an organization's narrative and trajectory to scrutinize consistency between internal values and external expressions (Lehman, O'Connor, Kovács, & Newman, 2019; Love & Kraatz, 2009). Overt expression of nationalism can cause backlash from foreign audiences (Yue et al., in press).

Ideological function

An organization may come to embody nationalism as its values, molding what scholars call its specific “character” and identities that guide the trajectory of its actions and future activities (King, 2015; Kraatz et al., 2020; Selznick, 1957). In this ideological function, nationalism shapes organizational discourses, activities, and decisions over time, directing members' attention to issues aligned with national priorities, such as fostering domestic development or safeguarding local markets (Ocasio, 1997; Rindova & Martins, 2017). They also provide moral criteria for evaluating strategic choices (Liedtka, 1989) and imbue everyday practices with a deeper purpose (Adler & Heckscher, 2018; Wrzesniewski et al., 1997). This pattern illustrates Weber's (1978) notion of “value rationality,” characterized by “the conscious belief in the value, for its own sake, of some ethical, religious, political, aesthetic, or other form of behavior, independently of its prospects of success” (p. 24). Takeda's (2025) historical study of Nippon Gakki (later Yamaha Corporation and Yamaha Motor Company) demonstrates how such nationalist commitments can guide a firm's development and internal culture across generations. These embedded values may also lead to rigidity or become “precarious” when changing markets or political environments clash with long-standing nationalist values (Kraatz et al., 2020; Risi & Marti, 2022; Selznick, 1957).

Four archetypes of organizational nationalism

Strategic and ideological functions are not positioned along a single continuum; each varies independently. We therefore propose a two-dimensional typology comprising four archetypes of organizational nationalism, as illustrated in Fig. 1.

Neutral

Neutral organizations prioritize economic or technical goals over nationalism. This aligns with visions of “nationless” firms (Chandler & Mazlish, 2005; Reich, 2010; Strange, 1996) where efficiency, innovation, and global scalability outweigh national identity, especially in sectors like software, fintech, or cross-border e-commerce (Ghemawat, 2007; Guillén, 2001; Jones, 2005). Neutrality may reflect tactical decisions shaped by stakeholder expectations or operate in low-visibility industries where nationalist appeals hold little value. Cosmopolitan goals often prevail when nationalism offers limited strategic or legitimacy benefits. For example, McKinsey & Company relies on commercially driven neutrality toward politics and national interests, enabling it to advise a wide range of global clients, including rival governments. Likewise, Stripe maintains a consistent global brand to support cross-border commerce. Both exemplify the “nationless” enterprise, where technical goals override national identity.

Instrumental

Organizations in this quadrant deploy nationalist themes to appeal to patriotic consumers, investors, or regulators without treating nationalism as a core value. This approach is common where nationalist sentiment or state influence is strong. For instance, domestic firms may

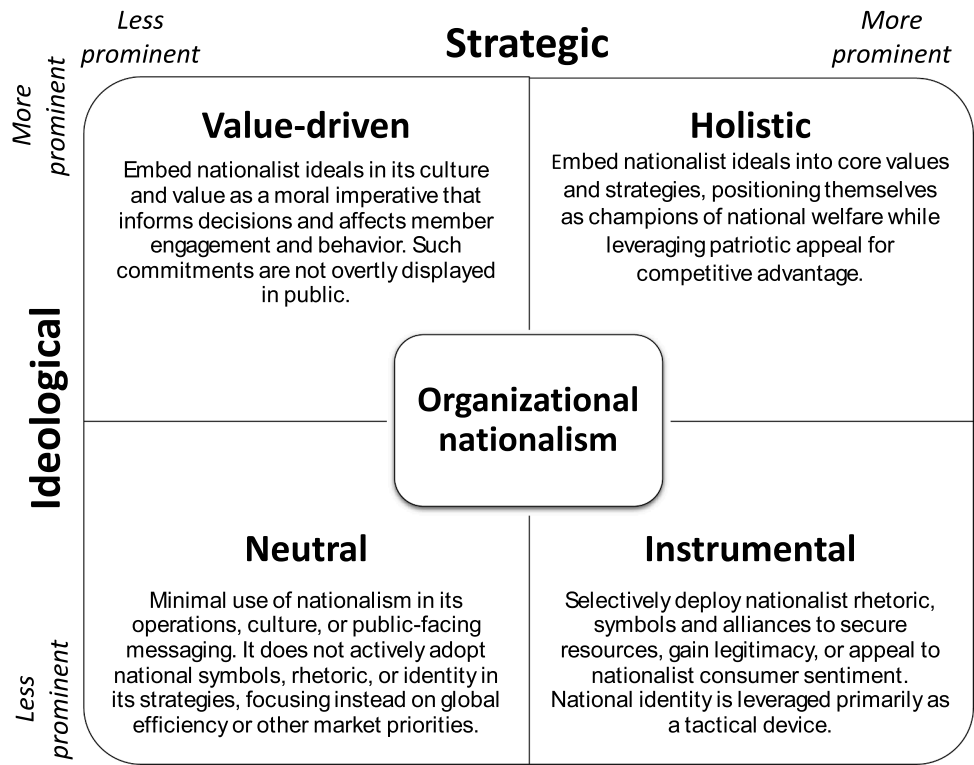


Fig. 1. Four Archetypes of Organizational Nationalism.

adopt “Made in [Home Country]” branding during trade conflicts (Frank, 2000), while foreign firms localize their identity to overcome liabilities of foreignness (Zaheer, 1995). During the 1980s and 1990s, Toyota, a Japanese automaker, faced trade tensions and anti-Japanese

sentiment in the United States. Beyond building U.S.-based production facilities for local job creation, Toyota mobilized marketing campaigns and community outreach efforts to highlight their “American-built” models to promote their image as an American company and community

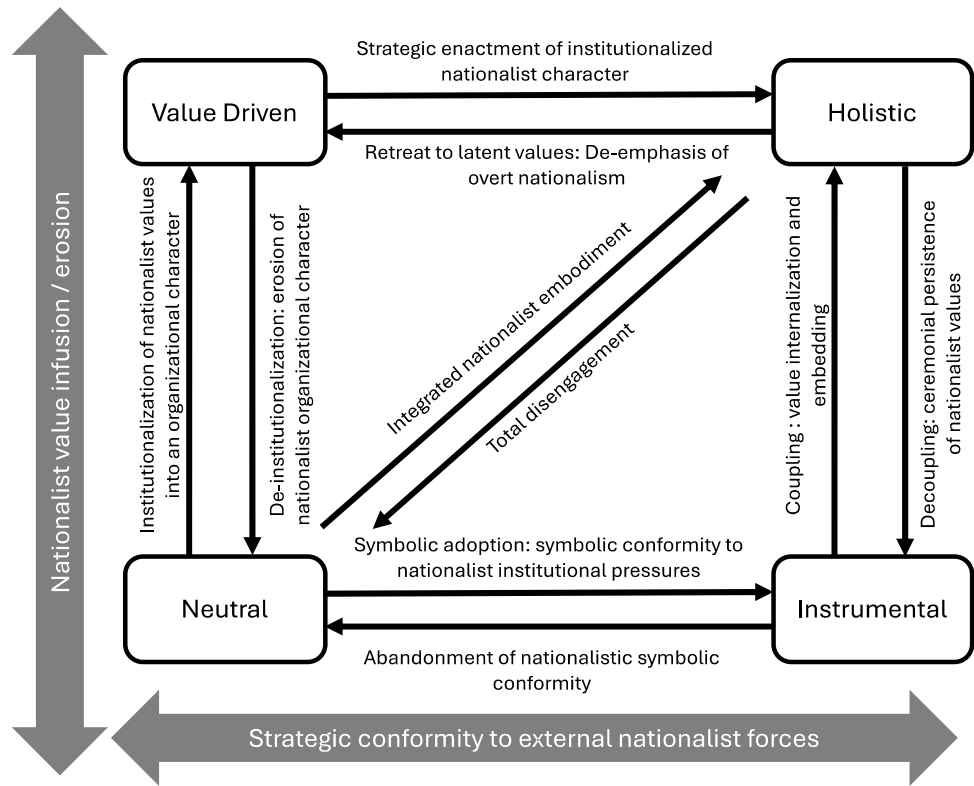


Fig. 2. Movements across archetypes.

partnerships (Florida & Kenney, 1991; Liker et al., 1999; Pil & MacDuffie, 1999).

Value-driven

These organizations view nationalism as a moral commitment embedded in organizational institutions, shaping their culture and decision-making. Nationalism provides long-term purpose and societal alignment. For example, SONY's founders, shaped by wartime experience, saw the company as a vehicle to restore Japan's global standing, guiding its innovation and international expansion (Koriyama, 2001). Nationalism can shape an organization's strategy and activities without overtly being nationalistic (Kraatz et al., 2020).

Holistic

Holistic organizations integrate nationalism into both strategy and ideology. They see themselves as national champions and use nationalist symbols to build internal cohesion and external legitimacy. This orientation often develops through long-term institutionalization (Dobbin, 1994; Selznick, 1957) or is reignited by external nationalist sentiment. Huawei exemplifies this model: it combines patriotic messaging with a military-style internal culture and positions itself as a technological bulwark of the nation (Dou, 2025).

Real-world organizations are dynamic and may shift among these archetypes (see Fig. 2). Shifts can be facilitated by significant changes in the external environment, such as regime changes, economic crises, or periods of war, which can alter the legitimacy and desirability of nationalist stances. Internal organizational changes, including the appointment of new leadership, mergers and acquisitions that introduce different organizational cultures, or declining performance that necessitates strategic re-evaluation, can also trigger a shift in nationalist orientation.

The mechanisms of these shifts can include decoupling (e.g., Meyer & Rowan, 1977; Tilcsik, 2010; Bromley & Powell, 2012), where an organization strategically separates its espoused nationalist values from its actual practices, transitioning from a holistic to a more instrumental approach. Distancing involves a further detachment from nationalist ideology, either instrumental or value-driven, towards a more neutral stance. Deinstitutionalization can occur when deeply embedded nationalist norms weaken over time due to changing societal values or competitive pressures (e.g., Clark, 1956; Kraatz, Ventresca, & Deng, 2010; Risi & Marti, 2022). Conversely, over-socialization, particularly within a stable institutional environment, can lead an organization to internalize nationalist values more deeply, moving from an instrumental adoption towards a value-driven or holistic integration (e.g., Koh, 2005; Selznick, 1992), which may be further reinforced by internal and external stakeholders (e.g., King, 2015). The consequences of such shifts can include lock-in and path dependence, where past nationalist commitments constrain future strategic choices. Maintaining external authenticity with stakeholders and ensuring internal consistency between espoused values and organizational practices become critical considerations during periods of transition.

An illustrative historical case of such evolution and the interplay between nationalist foundations and organizational values is found in Japanese corporate development, where nationalist foundations gave rise to socially responsible business philosophies. Early pioneers of Japanese capitalism, such as Yukichi Fukuzawa and Eiichi Shibusawa, urged firms to “serve the country” through management practices designed to strengthen Japan (Jones, 2023; Morikawa, 1973). This ideology evolved into one of managerial social responsibility and “managerial familism,” which views the corporation as a family that cares for its members (Hazama, 1997; Ishikawa, 1982), popularized as “Theory Z” (Ouchi, 1981).

Comparison with other related concepts

We further situate organizational nationalism within eight related

concepts in organizational research—*economic nationalism*, *techno-nationalism*, *resource nationalism*, *rhetorical nationalism*, *nationalist sentiment*, *patriotism*, *populism*, and *organizational political ideology*—and clarify how organizational nationalism intersects with, yet remains distinct from, each in Appendix 1. Overall, these concepts shed light on the broader ecosystem within which organizational nationalism unfolds. Policy-based forms of nationalism set the formal rules, public opinion provides the contextual backdrop, and rhetorical approaches and partisan ideologies reveal how organizations vary in their manifestations of nationalism. Organizational nationalism, however, goes a step further by emphasizing not just how organizations react to or adopt nationalist themes but how they *internalize* and *institutionalize* a nationalist stance, shaping their strategies, cultures, and stakeholder engagements from within.

Research agenda: a dynamic mediation framework of organizational nationalism

Building on our framework of organizational nationalism, we propose a research agenda that examines how organizations act as mediators between state and individual nationalism. Fig. 3 illustrates organizational nationalism as a dynamic, two-way system in which state-level, organizational, and individual forms of nationalism continually intersect and shape one another. In this dynamic, organizations do more than channel nationalist sentiment: they interpret, amplify, reshape, and transform it. By examining these processes, scholars can reveal how organizations reinforce state-driven nationalism or foster new forms of individual nationalist identification.

State-organization dynamics

Top-down mechanisms: from state nationalism to organizational nationalism

States have incentives to promote nationalism (see Smith, 2010; Bonikowski, 2016; Mylonas & Tudor, 2021 for reviews). Nationalism “holds that the political and the national unit should be congruent” (Gellner, 1983, p. 1) and often centers the state in nationalist aspirations. Nationalism helps states legitimize their rule, especially in the absence of other sources of legitimation or unifying ideologies (e.g., election, religion, or monarchy). Nationalism fosters a shared identity and sense of belonging (Morris, 2024). Nationalism can motivate the populace toward economic goals, such as productivity, modernization, or austerity (Johnson, 1982). Politicians often utilize nationalism to garner widespread support during periods of political fragmentation or economic downturns, as nationalist rhetoric can serve to distract from domestic failures or create scapegoats (Mudde, 2007).

While the state's nationalistic propaganda has been well-documented, the role organizations play as intermediaries remains less explored. State-led nationalist forces, such as economic nationalism, techno-nationalism, and resource nationalism, can shape organizational fields, creating environments conducive to organizational nationalism through coercive, normative, and mimetic mechanisms (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983). Understanding these top-down mechanisms shows how state actions affect corporate behavior and identity.

State power, manifested through policies and regulations, can directly compel or strongly incentivize organizations to adopt nationalist stances. The coercive power of a state is particularly strong when it has significant capacity for intervention. For example, during World War II, Japan's National Mobilization Law mandated private businesses' participation in military production to support imperial expansion projects (Skya, 2009). More broadly, adopting nationalist ideals, whether rhetorically or substantively, can serve as a strategic imperative for firms that depend on critical resources controlled by the state or state-aligned actors. Organizations that rely on government funding, contracts (such as federal contractors in the U.S.), or subsidies often find it advantageous, if not necessary, to align with national priorities. State-owned enterprises (SOEs), due to their direct ties, are

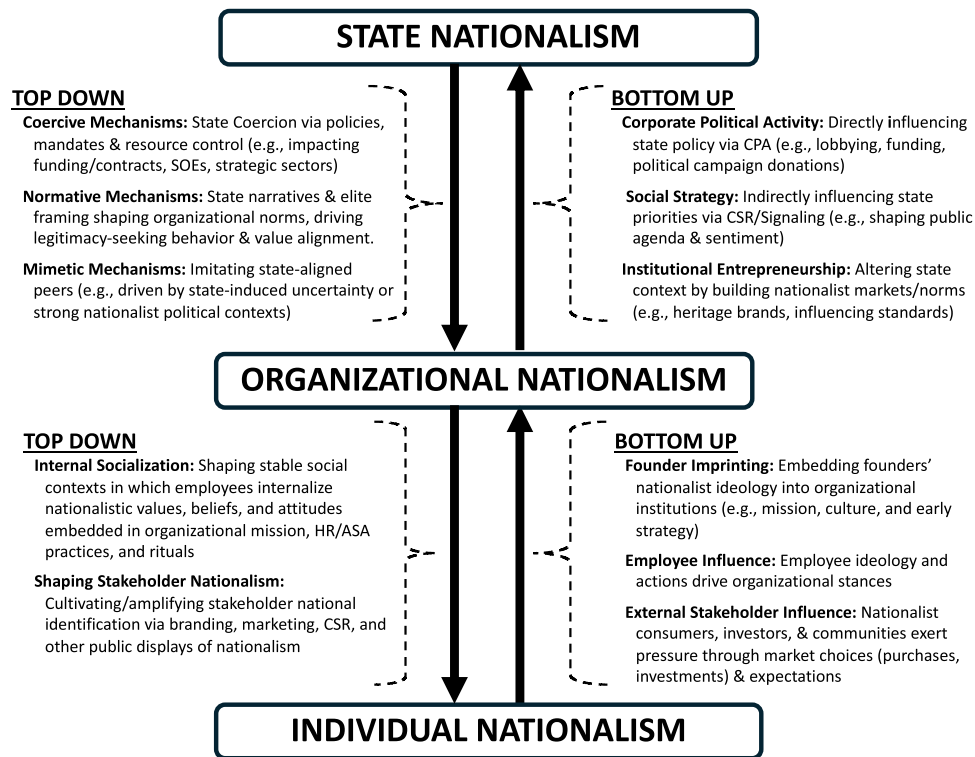


Fig. 3. Research Agenda: A Dynamic Mediation Framework of Organizational Nationalism.

demonstrably more likely to espouse nationalistic rhetoric (Yue et al., 2024), as are firms in sectors closely intertwined with government policy, such as defense and energy industries. Aligning with the state's nationalist agenda becomes a pathway to secure essential resources and maintain operational legitimacy.

Beyond direct coercion, states can catalyze organizational nationalism through normative pressures, shaping the cultural and symbolic landscape of organizational fields. Political leaders frequently invoke narratives of national belonging and allegiance to legitimize their authority and policies, effectively creating, developing, and spreading/popularizing the idea of the nation and the national community (Isaacs & Polese, 2016). These state-promoted narratives can shape sociocultural norms that define acceptable or desirable organizational forms and conducts in a given domain (Dacin, 1997). Organizations can internalize these narratives to gain social legitimacy. Through activities such as celebrating national holidays, touring the patriotic sites for team-building, or playing the national anthem at important organizational events, organizations integrate nationalism into their operational routine and signal their adherence to national values and interests.

Organizational nationalism can also diffuse through mimetic isomorphism, where organizations imitate the practices and postures of perceived successful or legitimate peers, especially under conditions of uncertainty (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983). As certain firms adopt nationalist strategies—perhaps in response to coercive or normative pressures—others may copy these behaviors to reduce ambiguity or signal conformity. While direct anecdotes require further empirical investigation, future research could explore whether firms operating within political contexts dominated by nationalist parties (e.g., firms in Republican-leaning U.S. states or countries with strong nationalist governments) are more likely to mimic nationalist rhetoric or practices observed in prominent local companies or industry leaders. Identifying the patterns and drivers of such mimetic behavior would further clarify how organizational nationalism spreads within and across industries. By examining these top-down coercive, normative, and mimetic pathways, research can better delineate how state-level nationalism translates into organizational practices, shaping firms into conduits—and sometimes

amplifiers—of national sentiment and priorities. This opens a fascinating theoretical frontier concerning the state's nationalist role not merely as a regulator of existing firms, but as an architect of new markets. Future researchers can study how states deploy nationalist ideology to mobilize social groups into new entrepreneurial roles, effectively constructing a new economic landscape to serve a nation-building agenda.

Importantly, acting as conduits or amplifiers of state nationalism can also expose organizations to political risks if governments change or the political landscape shifts. Volkswagen's history, both before and after WWII, is a notable illustration. Volkswagen (which translates to "People's Car") was founded in 1937 as a result of Adolf Hitler's nationalist aim to build an affordable car for the German Volksgemeinschaft. With the outbreak of war, the company shifted its production to military vehicles and relied heavily on forced labor (Gabler, 2016). In the post-war period, Volkswagen faced a reputational crisis, necessitating substantial rebranding and moral reckoning: its former association with the Nazi regime cast a shadow over its public image, even decades later.

Bottom-up mechanisms: from organizational nationalism to state nationalism

The interplay between state and organizational nationalism flows in both directions. Organizations are not merely passive recipients of nationalist pressures; they actively contribute to shaping state-level nationalism and the broader political landscape from the ground up. Through intentional strategies and by embedding nationalist ideals into their practices, firms influence national identity, public sentiment, and political priorities, thereby altering the environment in which the state operates.

One primary channel for this bottom-up influence is organizational political activity (CPA). Firms actively promote nationalist agendas via lobbying, campaign financing, and orchestrated public campaigns (Hillman et al., 2004). By framing specific economic issues, such as tariffs or subsidies, as matters of urgent national priority, companies can effectively sway both policymakers and public opinion. This influence is often reinforced through direct political contributions (Bonardi & Keim, 2005) or by mobilizing public sentiment against foreign competition

using advertising, social media, and grassroots initiatives (Wen et al., in press). An illustrative example is Cleveland-Cliffs CEO Lourenco Goncalves's January 2025 press conference, where he condemned Japan as "evil" and accused it of teaching China to "dump" steel in the US market (Kimball, 2025). Citing "national security" and "economic sovereignty," Goncalves leveraged nationalist language to justify his bid for U.S. Steel, influence policy outcomes, and shape public discourse, even potentially adversely impacting international relations. Future studies could explore how distinct nationalist frames—for instance, emphasizing job security versus "unfair" competition—shape popular attitudes under varied political conditions. Cross-national comparisons might also reveal how legal systems or cultural norms mediate the impact of nationalist lobbying. More broadly, examining how firms reconcile profit motives with nationalist appeals—and cope with backlash from foreign partners—can shed light on both the strategic advantages and moral dilemmas of deploying nationalism.

Organizational social strategy provides another avenue for bottom-up influence. Companies deploy corporate social responsibility (CSR) and philanthropic initiatives to signal commitment to the nation (Matten & Moon, 2008; Vogel, 2007). Supporting veterans, funding public infrastructure projects, or investing in the preservation of cultural heritage serves not only to bolster stakeholder trust and legitimacy but also to align the organization visibly with national values and priorities. While potentially enhancing corporate reputation, these actions can also subtly shape the national agenda by highlighting particular social issues or reinforcing specific visions of national identity and responsibility (Galaskiewicz & Colman, 2006; Cai et al., 2025). Over time, consistent corporate focus on specific socially framed national problems can influence societal sentiment and create an environment where state actors feel pressure to address these areas, thus demonstrating an indirect organizational influence on state priorities. Importantly, these bottom-up mechanisms can also reinforce social divisions and exclusionary narratives at the state level. Campaigns extolling local products or workers might implicitly depict foreign entities or immigrants as threats, hardening insider-outsider boundaries and influencing public attitudes towards globalization or immigration (Beaulieu & Balaji Venkatachalam, 2018; Glennon, 2024; Hernandez, 2024).

Beyond direct political and social strategies, organizations can shape the national context through institutional entrepreneurship. Firms may actively establish nationalist institutions or form alliances with them (Battilana, Leca, & Boxenbaum, 2009; Greenwood & Suddaby, 2006). Some companies collaborate with NGOs to advance nationalist goals, such as economic self-sufficiency, cultural preservation, or "buy local" campaigns. In defense and cybersecurity, firms often work with groups advocating military or technological sovereignty—U.S. defense contractor Lockheed Martin, for instance, has sponsored events promoting "America First" ideals (Harper, 2017). Other alliances yield commercial benefits: platforms like Public Square and Mammoth Nation team up with patriotic NGOs to attract nationalist consumers while also facilitating access to government contracts tied to nationalist policies (Gabbatt, 2024).

Furthermore, organizations may construct markets centered on national identity. Examples include building national heritage brands tied to cuisine, craft, or manufacturing, such as French Neuville Cuisine (Rao, Monin, & Durand, 2003), Indian art (Khair & Wadhwani, 2010), Swiss watches (Raffaelli, 2019), Quebec artisan cheese (Boghossian & David, 2021), or "Proudly Made in USA" products (Feng & Takeda, 2025; Frank, 2000), effectively unifying stakeholders around specific notions of national identity embedded in production and consumption. This bottom-up influence can build up fundamental influence for policy; firms themselves can become the catalysts of nationalist movements. Such an entrepreneurial form of nationalism, however, has gone largely unnoticed so far. Key research questions emerge: Under what conditions can entrepreneurs successfully legitimize new market categories predicated on national identity? How do different political environments—stable democracies versus fragile states or authoritarian

regimes—enable or hinder such nationalistic institutional work? Does this type of nationalist entrepreneurship lead to new forms of market gatekeeping through industry standards, labeling regulations, or certification programs?

Crucially, the bottom-up influence exerted through these political, social, and market-shaping strategies is not always benign; it can reinforce social divisions and exclusion. For instance, the "Canadian milk" campaign stoked public backlash and anti-trade sentiment by demonizing imports (Beaulieu & Balaji Venkatachalam, 2018). In polarized environments, such nationalist messaging by firms can harden insider-outsider boundaries, shaping public attitudes toward immigration (Glennon, 2024; Hernandez, 2024) and global cooperation (Karp & Zamiska, 2025), potentially creating public pressure for more exclusionary state policies. Organizations can thus actively impact the national context by influencing social norms, public sentiment, and market structures.

This reciprocal dynamic opens critical avenues for future research: Key questions remain regarding when, how, and why organizations effectively influence state nationalism to a greater or lesser degree, depending on factors like business sizes, industries, political connections, and political climates in which organizational, political, and social strategies are enacted.

Organization-individual dynamics

Top-down mechanisms: from organizational nationalism to individual nationalism

Organizations act as influential vehicles that translate their nationalist orientations into the beliefs and behaviors of individuals. They often have motivations for doing so. When an organization foregrounds national identity and presents itself as a proud representative of the nation, executives, employees, and external stakeholders are likely to experience a sense of pride and loyalty through shared identification. This emotional connection deepens individuals' attachment to the organization. Employees come to see their work not merely as a job, but as a contribution to the nation's progress, enhancing their self-worth and motivation. Likewise, domestic consumers, investors, and community members may perceive their purchasing decisions, financial support, or community engagement as acts of patriotic participation rather than routine transactions. Through this process of social identification, organizational nationalism can cultivate stronger loyalty, enhance reputational capital, and foster more cohesive and resilient stakeholder relationships.

The top-down influence from organizational nationalism to individual nationalism occurs through multiple mechanisms. One key mechanism involves organizations acting as socializing contexts for employees. As Selznick (1992) argued, "Much of socialization is routine learning of language, skills, attitudes, and beliefs," a process that can include internalizing "stereotyped ways of perceiving the world" (p. 152). Importantly, Selznick insists that this learning process relies on stable structures: "Socialization presumes what cannot be taken for granted: the stability of institutions" (ibid.). Organizations precisely offer such stable institutions. Within them, employees may internalize the specific language, attitudes, and beliefs needed to understand, appreciate, and express loyalty to the nation. Organizations actively cultivate particular understandings of national identity through internal communications, mission statements infused with national purpose, leadership rhetoric, and the deliberate use of national symbols. Workplace norms, routines, and specific HR practices, such as hiring criteria that favor nationals or performance evaluations that reward alignment with national interests, also influence employee attitudes, often subtly yet powerfully. Organizations provide the everyday context in which abstract national belonging is transformed into practical action (Billig, 1995; Schildkraut, 2011). They structure routines and interactions—participating in rituals celebrating national holidays, adhering to norms of national solidarity, and engaging with products coded as

patriotic—that allow individuals to perform their national identity. Over time, these dynamics can shape the workforce, potentially concentrating specific nationalist viewpoints through selection and attrition and turning the organization into an echo chamber that amplifies certain nationalistic beliefs (Barberá, 2020).

Furthermore, organizations can also influence the nationalistic beliefs and attitudes of external stakeholders. Through branding strategies that emphasize national origin (“Made in [Country]”), patriotic marketing campaigns, nation-themed product lines, and corporate socio-political stances aligned with national priorities, firms shape how individuals outside the organization engage with nationalism. Exposure to such corporate messaging can sway consumer purchasing decisions, making national identity a salient factor in market choices (Holt, 2006; Castelló & Mihelj, 2018). Similarly, aligning with national causes through corporate social responsibility (CSR) or public endorsements can influence investor perceptions and broader public opinion, thereby reinforcing nationalist sentiments within society. Additionally, employees who identify with an organization’s nationalist mission can serve as ambassadors in their communities. Through personal networks and social diffusion, they spread narratives and behaviors aligned with organizational nationalism.

As such, an organization’s nationalist stance critically mediates the relationship between the individual and the state, potentially resolving or amplifying conflicts arising from state-level nationalism. When an organization aligns with state ideology, it can amplify pressure on individuals to conform, thereby intensifying conflicts for those holding dissenting views. The firm essentially acts as a localized enforcer of state norms. Conversely, if an organization’s nationalism diverges from the state’s (e.g., promoting global integration amidst state protectionism), it might amplify conflict by providing a focal point for individuals resisting state directives. Alternatively, organizations might resolve conflict by buffering individuals from direct state pressures, offering a more cosmopolitan internal environment, or interpreting state mandates in ways more palatable to employees.

Exploring how organizational nationalism shapes the behavior of both employees and external stakeholders offers a promising avenue for future research. Currently, we have a limited understanding of how organizational nationalism—particularly when employed as a strategic orientation—interacts with other market and non-market strategies pursued by organizations. One compelling question is whether nationalistic rhetoric and practices influence an organization’s broader approach to stakeholder management. If nationalism helps organizations garner support from employees, consumers, investors, and local communities, might it also reduce the need for more costly initiatives, such as CSR programs aimed at enhancing stakeholder welfare? Emerging empirical evidence suggests that this may be the case: firms with pronounced rhetorical nationalism have been shown to pay lower taxes (Kazakis, 2024; Wang & Li, 2025). However, the relationship is not necessarily unidirectional. When organizational nationalism is internalized as a core value—rather than deployed solely as a strategic tool—it may encourage a stronger commitment to societal welfare, reflecting a belief that advancing the well-being of national constituents is integral to the organization’s mission of serving the nation.

At the same time, some nationalism-driven initiatives can impose significant costs, for instance, when corporations are mobilized for nation-building or tasked with spearheading foreign expansion projects. These tensions raise the possibility of strategic decoupling, wherein organizations publicly engage in nationalistic rhetoric while privately avoiding substantive commitments to national goals. This leads to a critical set of questions: how can organizations credibly signal to their employees and external stakeholders that their nationalism is grounded in intrinsic motivations and accompanied by meaningful contributions to national interests? And how can they avoid the perception of instrumentalism or hypocrisy, which risks undermining their legitimacy?

Understanding how organizations shape individual beliefs requires

closer attention to nationalism’s ideological function within the organization. Yet we know little about how nationalism operates within organizations—how it is embedded, maintained, and put to use. This “inside-out” process remains a theoretical black box. Unpacking it will require deep, longitudinal studies that trace how the value is interpreted and stewarded over time. For example, significant research is needed to disentangle the complex and evolving dynamics between organizational nationalism and individual identification. While existing literature on social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979, 1986) and organizational identification (Ashforth & Mael, 1989) provides a foundation, further research is needed to elucidate the specific mechanisms through which employees and external stakeholders internalize nationalist organizational cues.

Furthermore, the mechanisms of nationality-based exclusion in the workplace remain largely unaddressed (Köllen & Kopf, 2022). Key questions persist: How does discrimination based on national identity differ from or intersect with biases related to race, gender, or religion? Do certain individuals face a “double disadvantage,” or can national identity sometimes overshadow other social distinctions? Future studies should examine the effectiveness of various organizational mechanisms (e.g., HR practices vs. marketing) in shaping individual nationalism, considering how individual differences moderate these effects. Understanding how employees negotiate their own identity within nationalistic organizational cultures and how organizations mediate their relationship with the state is also critical. Addressing these questions will illuminate the powerful, often subtle ways in which organizations mold individual nationalism from the top down.

Bottom-up mechanisms: from individual nationalism to organizational nationalism

Individuals’ nationalist beliefs and actions, particularly those of founders, employees, and key stakeholders, can influence organizational nationalism from the bottom up. These mechanisms illustrate how personal convictions and collective sentiments are translated into organizational identities, values, and practices. Understanding these pathways is crucial for a comprehensive understanding of the dynamics between individuals and organizations in the context of nationalism.

A powerful bottom-up influence can occur at organizational inception through founder imprinting. Deeply embedded within their specific cultural and historical environments, founders can leave a lasting trace of their ideologies, including nationalist values, on their organizations (Marquis & Qiao, 2025; Stinchcombe, 1965). Marquis & Qiao (2020, 2022), for example, found that Chinese entrepreneurs imprinted by Mao’s political ideology were less likely to pursue internationalization strategies. Similarly, Mark Andol’s Made in America Store, launched in 2010, sold only “100 % American-made products”—from the shelves to the price tags—and framed this business as his protest against “the trade imbalance and unfair trade practices.”² Andol cast his venture’s mission “for the country, soldier, American worker, and our children of tomorrow.”³ Such examples echo historical precedents, like the Meiji-era Japanese entrepreneurs (e.g., Iwasaki Yataro, Shibusawa Eiichi) who launched businesses intertwined with nationalist drives for economic self-sufficiency and defense against Western powers (Hirschmeier, 1964; Morikawa, 1973; Westney, 1987). Similar patterns appear across various industrializing contexts where founders consciously projected nationalistic values through their ventures (Greenfeld, 1992).

Despite the clear impact of founders, significant research questions

² Made in America Store website, the December 9th, 2012 version of the “About Us” page. <http://web.archive.org/web/20121209143633/http://www.madeinamericastore.com/about/>

³ Made in America Store website, the August 10th, 2012 version of the “About Us” page. <http://web.archive.org/web/20121209143633/http://www.madeinamericastore.com/about/>

remain regarding these foundational imprints. How, why, and under what conditions do founding-time nationalist narratives solidify into enduring organizational values? The founders' background, such as prior military service or activist ties, may instill a distinct sense of moral obligation to champion national causes, leading to different imprint types compared to founders with more ambivalent positions. Furthermore, how do successor executives navigate or renegotiate these early nationalist commitments as political and market landscapes shift? Tracing the institutionalization and evolution of founding narratives can reveal the unique nationalist legacies organizations carry. Furthermore, the personal ideologies of founders often include distinct partisan values that can shape these initial nationalist imprints, and the ongoing partisan values of successor executives and influential employees can continue to influence the organization's nationalist expressions and commitments (e.g., [Chin et al., 2013](#); [Gupta et al., 2017](#)).

Beyond founders, the nationalist sentiments and actions of current employees also shape organizational nationalism from the bottom up. Employee activism—whether through organized rallies, protests, or internal mobilization—can pressure firms to adopt or reject specific nationalist stances. Facing such internal pressure, organizations may find themselves taking sides on contentious national issues, partly driven by a desire to represent or appease the prevailing sentiments, political ideologies, or dominant partisan values within their workforce (e.g., [Chin et al., 2013](#); [Gupta et al., 2017](#); [Hambrick & Wowak, 2021](#); [McKean & King, 2024](#)).

Influence also flows upward from external stakeholders whose identification with the nation translates into expectations for organizations. Consumers, driven by patriotism or consumer ethnocentrism, can reward firms perceived as loyal to the nation through brand loyalty while punishing those seen as foreign or unaligned ([Shankarmahesh, 2006](#); [Holt, 2006](#); [Castelló & Mihelj, 2018](#)). Similarly, investors may channel funds toward companies viewed as nationally significant, influencing market dynamics ([Bonaparte et al., 2017](#); [Morse & Shive, 2011](#)). Furthermore, pressure arises from local communities expecting national contributions and activist groups mobilizing individuals around specific nationalist causes ([Gabbatt, 2024](#)). These varied bottom-up pressures, manifesting through market choices and explicit demands for loyalty and alignment, significantly influence corporate communication and strategy.

Further research is needed to explore how organizations sense and respond to these diverse bottom-up pressures from employees and various external stakeholder groups. What factors determine whether organizations align with, resist, or attempt to manage these demands? How does the workforce's internal political composition—including the spectrum of employee and leadership partisan values (e.g., [Chin et al., 2013](#); [Gupta et al., 2017](#)) or activist orientation, interact with external stakeholder pressures to shape the organization's manifested nationalism? Investigating these bottom-up channels—from the deep historical roots of founder imprinting to the ongoing pressures exerted by employees and stakeholders—is crucial for understanding how individual-level nationalism flows upward to shape organizational identity and behavior.

Consequences and mechanisms for organizational performance

Organizational nationalism has direct consequences for firms, presenting a complex mix of potential benefits and significant risks. An obvious, yet critical, area for future research concerns how organizational nationalism affects organizational performance. On the one hand, embracing nationalism can enhance strategic positioning, financial returns, and reputation, particularly in domestic markets. The research by Yue and colleagues' research (2024; [in press](#)) on Chinese public firms reveals that corporate rhetorical nationalism is associated with higher returns on assets and that endorsing specific nationalist movements can enhance short-term stock prices and local sales. Similarly, [Mohr and Schumacher \(2019\)](#) show that U.S. firms' patriotic rhetoric is positively

associated with their performance when the nationalist sentiment in the domestic society is high. Furthermore, leveraging both Federal Trade Commission (FTC) investigations and field experiments, [Kong and Rao \(2021\)](#) find that "Made in USA" claims can increase consumer willingness-to-pay by as much as 28 % and that the removal of such claims results in significant sales declines. [Benos and Jochec \(2012\)](#) also find that US companies whose names contain the words "America(n)" or "USA" earned approximately 6 % positive abnormal returns during nationalism-heightened eras, such as World War II, the Korean War, and the War on Terrorism.

Nonetheless, nationalist appeals can backfire in international contexts. Foreign stakeholders may view overtly nationalistic firms with suspicion, perceiving them as extensions of their home governments. This perception can undermine trust, limit organizational adaptability, and hinder vital cross-border collaborations ([Choudhury et al., 2025](#); [Edman et al., 2024](#)). An overemphasis on national identity can hinder cultural integration in host countries and lead to increased regulatory scrutiny abroad. Nationalistic Chinese firms are more likely to pursue cross-border acquisitions, but their attempts also face a higher likelihood of failure ([Yue, Qiao, Yan, & Li, 2025](#)). Furthermore, Chinese firms endorsing a controversial nationalist movement face declines in overseas sales ([Yue et al., in press](#)). Similarly, [Mohr and Schumacher \(2019\)](#) report that US firms that adopt patriotic rhetoric face performance declines when they are highly involved in overseas markets. These findings highlight the acute strategic trade-offs that multinational corporations (MNCs) must navigate between cultivating domestic appeal and maintaining global legitimacy.

Future research should also investigate the mechanisms through which organizational nationalism affects performance. Beyond the market trade-offs between domestic and international sales, scholars can examine internal organizational mechanisms such as executive teams' information processing capabilities, innovation potential, and employee morale. For instance, a study of Swiss publicly listed firms found that greater national diversity within top management teams is associated with superior financial performance ([Nielsen & Nielsen, 2013](#)). Similarly, [Lee et al. \(2025\)](#) reported that the international diversity of top management teams in foreign subsidiaries has a positive influence on the innovation capabilities of Korean multinational corporations. [Ghemawat and Vantrappen \(2015\)](#) further argued that promoting foreign nationals to C-suite positions can impact middle managers' morale, as such decisions shape their perceptions of upward mobility within the organization. Together, these findings highlight the importance of examining the consequences of organizational nationalism and identifying the mechanism through which it may enhance or undermine firms' performance and strategic decision-making.

Dimensionality of organizational nationalism

Future research might probe the antecedents, processes, and outcomes that shape each of the four sub-dimensions and archetypes of organizational nationalism. One promising line of inquiry concerns the conditions under which organizations emphasize national pride versus anti-foreign sentiment—or, by contrast, avoid either stance. Might peaceful events such as scientific breakthroughs or sports victories sometimes trigger exclusionary rhetoric rather than unite stakeholders under a banner of collective pride? Conversely, do geopolitical tensions or trade disputes inevitably heighten outgroup bias, or are there circumstances under which they can prompt more inclusive or "value-driven" national visions? Another fruitful avenue is to explore how organizations navigate tensions between a newly adopted nationalist stance and their historical commitments, especially if they have long occupied a "neutral" or globally oriented position. Scholars could ask whether firms that begin with "instrumental" appeals become locked into a more "holistic" nationalism as stakeholders reinforce those messages over time or if some organizations shift back toward more neutral ground. Investigating these dynamics can reveal how organizational

nationalism develops, evolves, and changes firms' cultural and strategic orientations. Furthermore, understanding these dynamics of evolution and change naturally raises a parallel question of endurance. Given that nationalism's meaning is tied to a nation's shifting sociopolitical context, how an organization sustains its nationalist values and commitments over the *longue durée* remains a critical, yet underexplored, dimension of organizational nationalism.

These research agendas position organizations not as passive bystanders but as central actors within the complex, multi-level system of nationalism. By investigating the antecedents, diverse processes, and wide-ranging consequences of organizational nationalism—including its impact on state-organization dynamics, organization-individual relations, and organizational performance—scholars can significantly advance our understanding. Treating organizational nationalism as both a product of broader sociopolitical forces and an agent capable of reshaping those forces illuminates the mechanisms through which organizations reflect *and* recast the politics of nationhood. These questions hold considerable scholarly potential, bridging insights from organizational theory, political science, sociology, and psychology. Moreover, in an era marked by resurgent nationalism and geopolitical shifts, this research offers crucial insights for managers navigating complex stakeholder demands, for policymakers grappling with the role of business in society, and for citizens seeking to understand how the organizations shaping their daily lives also shape their sense of national belonging. Unpacking the dynamics of organizational nationalism is thus not merely an academic exercise; it is essential for comprehending and potentially steering the powerful interplay between business, society, and the state in the twenty-first century.

Discussion on organizational nationalism theory

To further contextualize our theory of organizational nationalism, we explore several key facets: the varied roles of organizations in relation to nationalism, the interplay of civic and ethnic forms within them, the pressing normative questions they raise, and the framework's broader applicability, including its implications for multinational corporations.

Beyond the carrier role: alternate organizational positions in nationalism

While our framework emphasizes organizations as active transmitters of nationalism, they may also assume other roles. First, some organizations may play a *resistance role* in countering nationalism. Civil and social movement organizations may advocate for marginalized identities against exclusionary nationalist pressures (Kellogg, 2009; Rao & Dutta, 2012; Yue et al., 2019). In defiance of dominant nationalist narratives, organizations such as the American Indian Movement and Canada's First Peoples' Cultural Council promote Indigenous culture. Similarly, companies such as Patagonia have backed indigenous land rights and worked with native communities to challenge exclusionary national ideologies.

In other cases, transnational actors can play an *external influencer role* in shaping nationalism. Supranational bodies like the EU may diffuse cosmopolitan ideals or provoke nationalist backlash (e.g., Brexit). NGOs, multilateral organizations, and international trade bodies can unintentionally disrupt nationalist agendas by imposing human rights, sustainability, or sovereignty norms. Finally, organizations can engage in *corporate-state collaboration*. Historically, companies have co-produced nationalist institutions. The East India Company, for example, combined commercial activity with colonial governance across India (Bucheli, 2005; Dalrymple, 2019; Philips, 2011; Travers, 2007). State-owned enterprises and public-private partnerships today can similarly advance national strategic goals—blurring the line between corporate agency and state power.

Inclusive vs. exclusive nationalism: civic and ethnic strains

A longstanding distinction in nationalism research contrasts civic and ethnic nationalism (Bonikowski, 2016; Smith, 2010). Civic nationalism defines national identity based on a shared faith in inclusive democratic political institutions, values, and citizenship; ethnic nationalism defines membership through ancestry, language, and religion. Organizational nationalism can mirror both forms. Firms may cultivate emotional ties through ascriptive factors like cultural symbols, regional pride, or religious affiliations, rooting legitimacy in ethnic nationalism. For example, companies may sponsor religious holidays or invoke ancestral narratives that deepen bonds with a particular community. However, such appeals may exclude those who do not share these traits. Conversely, organizations aligned with civic nationalism may focus on constitutional values or public service, appealing to a broader—though perhaps less fervent—stakeholder base. These two orientations may differ in reach, emotional intensity, and normative implications, raising questions about the inclusivity of organizational nationalism.

The normative question: is organizational nationalism good or bad?

Scholars and observers have long debated nationalism's normative implications (Gellner, 1983; Smith, 2010). Critics argue that as nationalism resurfaces in various regions, it has the potential to undermine moral values, foster racism, and strengthen authoritarianism (Brubaker, 1996; Mann, 2005; Snyder, 2018). Internationally, overemphasizing national sovereignty can exacerbate interstate rivalries or spark a populist backlash against multilateral institutions (Krasner, 1999; Mounk, 2018). History also shows nationalism's emancipatory potential. Since the late eighteenth century, nationalist movements have united colonized and marginalized peoples against imperial forces, sparking freedom and justice movements (Chatterjee, 1986; Fanon, 1963; Greenfeld, 1992; Hobsbawm, 1990). John Stuart Mill famously argued that “[f]ree institutions are next to impossible in a country made up of different nationalities” (1861, p. 289). Alexis de Tocqueville also observed, “there is nothing in the world but patriotism and religion that can make the universality of citizens advance for long toward the same goal” (1835/2000, p.89).

In this regard, contemporary theorists often prefer a civic, liberal-democratic nationalism over an ethnic, ascriptive one (Keating, 2001; Wimmer, 2002). Fukuyama (2018a, 2018b, 2023) clarifies this position: “National identity as a liberal and open society is something of which liberals can be justly proud, and their tendency to downplay national identity has allowed the extreme right to claim this ground. ... Citizenship should convey a two-way bargain conveying acceptance of the social contract and should be a point of pride” (Fukuyama, 2023, p. 137).

Organizational nationalism presents a similar duality. Firms can rally employees, customers, and communities around shared goals, particularly during crises or national rebuilding efforts. For instance, businesses contributing to public infrastructure, healthcare, or disaster relief may boost morale and legitimacy. Yet, organizations that promote narrow definitions of national identity may marginalize outsiders, limit workforce diversity, and reduce global adaptability. Understanding when organizational nationalism promotes cohesion versus division is a critical research agenda.

Generalizability of organizational nationalism framework

We next turn to the question of our framework's generalizability. As illustrated by the diverse examples presented in this article, organizational nationalism is not confined to a single country or regime type. Our theoretical framework—encompassing the content, archetypes, and intermediary roles of organizational nationalism—is not inherently dependent on specific political systems or cultural traditions. Regarding

empirical evidence, we find diverse examples where organizations from different countries invoke and embody nationalism. There exist consistent quantitative findings regarding antecedents and consequences for these organizations to engage with nationalism in different national settings. The difference in organizational nationalism across political regimes and societal traditions, therefore, may be one of degree rather than of kind.

Accordingly, we consider our theoretical framework to have broad applicability across different national contexts. That said, it is important to recognize that distinct historical and sociopolitical environments shape the specific forms and expressions of organizational nationalism. For example, in authoritarian regimes, where governments often exert greater control over economic and political resources, organizational nationalism may more explicitly align with or demonstrate allegiance to state authority. In democratic contexts where civil society plays a more prominent role in shaping the political landscape and societal discourse, organizational nationalism may draw more heavily on populist or grassroots nationalistic rhetoric to build legitimacy and resonance. Future study could benefit from comparative analyses that investigate both the similarities and differences in organizational nationalism across countries. Scholars can deepen and broaden the theoretical framework by taking into account differences in political regimes, cultural traditions, and historical trajectories.

Organizational nationalism and multinational corporations

Although much discussion thus far has discussed a single-country context, organizational nationalism is particularly relevant for multinational corporations (MNCs) operating across borders. As globalization slows and national priorities resurge, MNCs sit at the fault line. When domestic firms expand abroad, their ties to nationalism become more complex. MNCs must meet nationalist expectations at home, often embedded in their identity and strategy, while navigating conflicting nationalist sentiments in host countries (Yiu et al., 2022). This dynamic gives rise to strategic and legitimacy paradoxes. Sometimes, MNCs may embody organizational nationalism in one context while facing a “liability of foreignness” or accusations of threatening national interests in another (Arikan & Shenkar, 2013; Choudhury, Jandhyala, & Nandkumar, 2025; Luo, 2022; Shi, Hoskisson, & Zhang, 2016; Zaheer, 1995). In other scenarios, particularly when MNCs’ home and host nations are entangled in geopolitical conflicts, appealing to nationalism in one might lead to legitimacy loss in the other.

Recent work has begun to examine how nationalism affects MNCs’ hybridization of dissimilar practices and routines (Edman et al., 2024), cross-border governance (Ertug et al., 2024), and their hiring practices (Wang & Zhang, 2025; Zhang et al., 2025). However, much remains unknown about how organizational nationalism travels across borders and adapts to divergent political environments. These questions have become more urgent amid rising economic nationalism (Bucheli, 2010; Choudhury et al., 2025), techno-nationalism (Li et al., 2024; Luo, 2022; Luo & Van Assche, 2023), and broader deglobalization trends (Teece, 2022). MNCs face mounting pressure to reconcile nationalist demands while managing heightened geopolitical risk (Lubinski & Wadhvani, 2020). Lai & Fortwengel (in press) show that Huawei initially cast itself as a “national industry revitalizer,” invoking *Fen Dou*—“struggle and sacrifice for the nation.” As it expanded globally, Huawei softened this message. It reframed *Fen Dou* as “dedication” and adopted the language of an “international corporate citizen.” More recently, as geopolitical tensions escalated, Huawei repurposed *Fen Dou* to signal a fighting spirit and rebranded itself as a “global technology leader” serving all humanity. Here, nationalist identity acted as a double-edged sword, providing cultural resonance while exposing the firm to political risk.

The organizational nationalism framework provides a powerful lens for analyzing such dynamics. It helps explain how MNCs leverage different dimensions of nationalism to craft narratives to engage diverse stakeholders, develop different nationalism archetypes (neutral,

instrumental, value-driven, and holistic) across subsidiaries, and evolve their messaging as they internationalize. MNCs may even employ political and social strategies to influence government policies and shape stakeholder perceptions. Doing so may help MNC create an image of being loyal to both home and host countries. Powerful MNCs may play a role in mediating diplomatic relationships between countries (Bucheli et al., 2024). Understanding such patterns is vital in a decoupling global economy, where national allegiances and firm strategies are intertwined (e.g., Ambos, Cesinger, Eggers, & Kraus, 2020; Teece, 2022; Witt, 2019).

Methodological approaches

Various methods can be used to study organizational nationalism. We discuss five promising approaches, their strengths and limitations, and best practices for implementation.

Computational text analytics

Computational text analytics—combining Natural Language Processing (NLP), machine learning, and large-scale text analysis—offers a powerful way to study how organizations express sentiments in their official discourse (Hassan et al., 2019; Lawson et al., 2022; Benton et al., 2022). By systematically examining corporate documents, policy statements, and public communications, researchers can uncover patterns in nationalist language at both organizational and societal levels. For instance, Yue et al. (2024) used word-embedding models on annual reports to identify nationalistic terms and develop a firm-level “rhetorical nationalism” score. Yiu et al. (2022) measured societal-level nationalist sentiment by analyzing the text of blog posts. This approach proves valuable for tracking how nationalist rhetoric emerges, evolves, and diffuses over time. Advantages include scalability (covering many firms and extended periods), the ability to convert qualitative data into quantifiable measures, and detection of semantic patterns via topic modeling or sentiment analysis.

Ongoing advances in Large Language Models (LLMs) continue to improve the accuracy and efficiency of parsing and quantifying textual content. LLMs enable researchers to capture nuanced meanings by accounting for contextual cues and can be fine-tuned or prompted to analyze nationalist sentiment within specific domains—such as news media, product reviews, or country-specific contexts—allowing for more precise interpretation of nationalistic language. With appropriate modifications, advanced LLMs can also support multilingual sentiment analysis, which is particularly valuable for detecting nationalist expressions and sentiments across different national settings. Moreover, when properly optimized, LLMs can be deployed for real-time monitoring of nationalist sentiment on platforms such as social media, customer feedback systems, or financial news outlets, offering timely insights for researchers and practitioners.

Nevertheless, computational methods are not without limitations and must be used in tandem with human judgment. For example, nationalist expressions that reflect the dominant political or cultural agenda of a specific country (i.e., dominant societal agenda) at a given time are highly context-sensitive. Human interpretation and contextual expertise are essential for guiding the design and application of computational models. Researchers should curate high-quality, domain-specific training datasets and may incorporate techniques such as multi-label classification or few-shot learning to address ambiguity and subjectivity (Wang et al., 2020). These limitations can be further mitigated by triangulating computational findings with complementary sources, including archival materials and qualitative evidence.

Historical and case study research

Historical and case study research rely on an archive-based and context-sensitive approach to explanation (Ingram, Rao, & Silverman, 2012; Kipping & Üsdiken, 2014; Yin, 2017). Researchers piece evidence

from various sources—archival records, government documents, personal letters, and organizational data—to build narratives of how processes unfold over time. This approach is particularly effective for research questions requiring multi-level and multi-causal “systems” explanations (Hargadon & Wadhvani, 2022; Ingram, Rao, & Silverman, 2012; Vaara & Lamberg, 2016).

Historically minded organizational scholars have already established precedents in examining how nationalism intersects with organizational practices (e.g., Bucheli, 2005, 2010; Bucheli et al., 2023; Kalev et al., 2008; Lubinski & Wadhvani, 2020). Their work highlights why historical methods are compelling for studying organizational nationalism: With them, we can capture the interactions among social, political, economic, and cultural variables that simpler, cross-sectional methods may miss. Through primary and secondary documents, as well as in-depth case studies, scholars can trace the origins of organizational behaviors, assess how they adapt or persist, and examine how external forces—from state interventions to cultural sentiments—shape organizational nationalism.

Like other methodologies, historical approaches face notable constraints. First, empirical generalizability can be limited because of its deep dive into the history of particular firms or industries, extrapolating generalizable theories from historical particularities can be a strenuous endeavor. Explicit theorization of boundary conditions and analytical transferability, therefore, is critical (Yin, 2017). Second, archival constraints can influence what researchers can and cannot study. Materials may be incomplete, scattered across multiple repositories, or intentionally censored. Researchers must account for source dependability when concluding from available evidence: For historical research to be rigorous, researchers must (1) question the intent and context of source production (“source criticism” and “hermeneutics”) and (2) explore and compare alternative explanations and disconfirming evidence (Kipping & Wadhvani, & Bucheli, 2014; Schrag, 2021). Third, causality in historical work relies on careful contextual interpretation and analytical reasoning. Historians test causal claims by shifting through competing explanations, tracking outcomes over time, or comparing multiple cases. These inferences rely on the narrative’s persuasiveness and the evidence’s consistency rather than interventions or statistical identification techniques that rely on experimental logic. Many scholars nonetheless find historical methods immensely effective for revealing processes that quantitative and experimental methods cannot (Kipping & Üsdiken, 2014). Overall, the ability to rigorously examine multiple variables across different levels of analysis and time makes historical and case-based methods ideal for studying organizational nationalism, which is inherently dynamic and multi-level.

Experimental approach

Experiments allow researchers to pinpoint causal effects by randomly assigning participants to conditions—such as exposure to nationalistic cues or “Made in [Home Country]” labels—and measuring subsequent attitudes or behaviors. By manipulating a single factor in controlled settings, scholars can observe how subtle appeals to national pride activate in-group biases (Searle-White, 2001). This method is beneficial for exploring consumer responses to nationalistic branding: numerous marketing studies find that patriotic icons or language can lead participants to judge domestic products more favorably and increase their purchase intentions (Fischer & Zeugner-Roth, 2017; Zeugner-Roth, Žabkar, & Diamantopoulos, 2015). Experiments also help identify which audiences—consumers with strong national identities, for instance, or employees receptive to patriotic themes—are most influenced by such messages.

Despite these advantages, experiments have notable drawbacks. By relying on brief online tasks or laboratory settings, they often fail to capture the broader cultural, temporal, or organizational factors that shape the real-world significance of nationalism. Simulating these macro contexts through simple prompts is difficult, and researchers risk

creating “manipulation artifacts.” In other words, overtly nationalistic language may unintentionally prime xenophobia or exaggerated cultural pride that does not reflect genuine marketplace behavior. Thus, scholars must design interventions carefully, addressing both ethical issues (e.g., reinforcing stereotypes) and interpretive challenges (e.g., mistaking artificially induced responses for true beliefs). Pairing experiments with archival approaches can mitigate these concerns and offer both the precision of controlled testing and the depth needed to examine organizational nationalism comprehensively.

Survey and archival research

The combination of survey and archival methods helps scholars investigate the micro-level underpinnings of nationalism and its macro-level organizational outcomes (Morse & Shive, 2011; Canayaz & Darendeli, 2024; Callens & Meuleman, 2024). Surveys, such as the General Social Survey (GSS), World Values Survey, and International Social Survey Programme (ISSP), can measure public attitudes on nationalism, trade, and immigration, helping researchers pinpoint the social forces at play. For instance, Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016) used GSS data to classify individuals into different nationalist orientations and link those orientations to broader political and economic preferences. Archival data, meanwhile, provide insights into how firms respond to nationalist pressures, whether through their strategies, financial performance, or global expansions. For example, Li et al. (2024) drew on M&A records and policy documents to correlate shifts in geopolitical factors with changes in corporate behavior. By combining these methods, researchers can capture the interplay between individual-level sentiments and organizational decision-making, yielding a nuanced understanding of how nationalism operates across multiple layers of analysis.

Despite its strengths, this survey–archival approach has notable limitations. First, it often reveals correlations rather than providing definitive causal evidence. Second, social desirability bias in surveys can skew responses if participants offer socially acceptable answers instead of their true opinions. Third, surveys and archival data are typically retrospective, making capturing swift changes in nationalism-driven decision-making difficult. Even so, these methods remain a powerful means of linking nationalistic sentiment to organizational behavior at multiple levels, offering valuable insights into how public attitudes intersect with firm strategies.

Event study

The event study method examines the short- or medium-term impact of specific events—often referred to as “shocks” or flashpoints—on organizations, stakeholders, and markets. Policy changes, major elections, geopolitical conflicts, diplomatic disputes, and sporting events can stir nationalist sentiment and affect corporate behavior (Chavis & Leslie, 2009; Fisman et al., 2014; Weiss et al., 2023). Shi and Wei (2023) analyzed consumer purchasing data before and after boycott announcements to assess the impact of nationalistic consumer boycotts on multinational corporations’ revenues. Yue et al. (in press) studied the investors’ reactions to corporations’ endorsement of a nationalist social movement. This method is ideal for studying organizational nationalism in response to specific events with a well-defined time window and outcome, such as firms’ financial performance, consumer purchasing behavior, and strategic moves like market entry, exit, M&As, and R&Ds.

The event study approach also has limitations. First, it centers on immediate responses, potentially overlooking the long-term strategic effects of nationalist events. Second, it is affected by event rarity and specificity, which makes it challenging to examine different aspects of organizational nationalism in a single study. Third, event studies are unsuitable for examining subtle, evolutionary changes in corporate culture, strategies, or internal decision-making processes. Event studies are most helpful in studying short-term responses to an exogenous event.

Researchers should select an approach based on the aspects of

organizational nationalism that interest them the most. Combining methods can help overcome their drawbacks and produce robust analyses that capture the complexities of organizational nationalism.

Conclusion

We introduced *organizational nationalism*—a new perspective on how organizations engage with nationalism. Our theory illuminates a new empirical reality: A “borderless world” based on free-market universalism has given way to “our nation first” priorities, prompting many organizations to embrace their national identities and loyalty. We developed a framework that encompasses the content, archetypes, and intermediary role of organizational nationalism. We then presented a set of promising methodological approaches. Below, we discuss the contributions of organizational nationalism theory to the broader studies of nationalism and the literature on organizational management, as well as its practical implications.

We see three major contributions of the organizational nationalism theory: (1) filling in a void in the literature, (2) changing a view on organizations, and (3) providing an organizational account of an important social reality. First, for broader nationalism studies, organizational nationalism provides a critical “missing middle” between macro-level studies of states and nation-building and micro-level investigations of individual identity formation (Bonikowski, 2016; Mylonas & Tudor, 2021; Smith, 2010). While earlier work has centered on how governments cultivate national ideals or how individuals internalize them, it has largely overlooked the pivotal role of organizations. Organizations, like enthusiastic citizens of a country, can be promoters and propagators of nationalism, as well as provide a social context in which individuals experience both the positive and negative aspects of nationalism. As such, the organizational perspective fills a significant void in the research on nationalism and advances organizations as a critical unit of analysis.

Second, the organizational nationalism theory posits that organizations are *active agents* in nationalism, challenging the prevailing view that nationalism primarily operates as an external constraint. Prior research in international business and institutional theory has mainly

depicted nationalism as a form of state control or a source of liability for multinational firms. By contrast, organizational nationalism recognizes how firms can actively leverage nationalist sentiment to build stakeholder relationships, enhance employee commitment, access state support, and cultivate legitimacy among domestic consumers. This perspective opens a conceivably wide range of new research programs to understand better how organizations manage their identity and values in a time of rising geopolitical tension. Furthermore, we articulated the *content* of organizational nationalism, developed a structured *typology*, and proposed a research *roadmap* to help unify and advance scholarship on nationalism in organizational life. We encourage more research into organizational nationalism in various settings and time horizons using varied methodologies.

Finally, as Keating (2001, p. xvii) reminds us, “nationalism ... is part of the political reality, and we need to live with it, seeking to accommodate it ... to foster its positive aspects and restrain the negative ones.” We agree—that organizational researchers must confront the realities of nationalism head-on as informed participants. Whether it confers moral clarity or poses strategic hazards, unites or excludes, or affords new possibilities or imposes constraints, nationalism compels our attention. Organizational behavior and theory offer critical insights into an important aspect—the role of organizations—of this far-reaching political and social phenomenon. Of utmost importance, it enables us to discern when organizations channel nationalism toward collective progress—and when they perpetuate division, rigidity, or harm.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Yusaku Takeda: Writing – original draft. **Lori Qingyuan Yue:** Writing – original draft.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendix 1. Comparison of organizational nationalism with related concepts

Most invoked concepts of nationalism focus on how states shape or protect national interests, typically treating organizations as policy takers rather than policy shapers. *Economic nationalism* underscores state-led interventions—such as tariffs, subsidies, or procurement policies—to defend domestic industries (Nielsen, 1979; Zhang & He, 2014; Bucheli et al., 2023). *Techno-nationalism* highlights the strategic value of high-tech sectors to national security and influence, emphasizing state initiatives to foster technological superiority (Luo, 2022; Luo & Van Assche, 2023; Li et al., 2024). *Resource nationalism* similarly centers on state control over oil, minerals, and other strategic resources (Click & Weiner, 2010; Bucheli & Aguilera, 2010). These concepts describe the institutional environments in which firms operate but do not address how organizations themselves may adopt, embody, or amplify nationalist imperatives. They provide a societal, institutional environment in which organizational nationalism may perpetuate.

Other concepts center on social attitudes toward nationhood in ways similar to organizational nationalism but at different levels of analysis or on other group identities. *Nationalist sentiment* reflects national pride or chauvinism in a society (Yiu et al., 2022; Dow & Cuypers, 2024), functioning as an exogenous force that can spur or constrain organizational nationalism. Likewise, *patriotism* denotes loyalty and attachment to one’s country without necessarily disparaging outsiders (Kosterman & Feshbach, 1989). While patriotism overlaps with nationalism as a form of national attachment, its non-exclusionary bent may not always trigger or sustain anti-foreignness in organizational nationalism (Mohr & Schumacher, 2019). *Populism*, by contrast, centers on a divide between “the people” and “the elite” (Blake et al., 2024; Corina et al., 2025), not a domestic-versus-foreign antagonism.

Corporate rhetorical nationalism more directly intersects with organizational nationalism, considering how firms publicly deploy nationalist language and symbols to signal alignment with national interests (Yue et al., 2024). Corporate rhetorical nationalism highlights an important dimension of organizational nationalism—how nationalism is communicated to stakeholders—but it generally focuses on corporate discourse and may not capture substantive commitments. In contrast, organizational nationalism also encompasses a firm’s policies, internal practices, and interactions with various stakeholders that collectively define its nationalist orientation. Corporate rhetorical nationalism can be viewed as a *component* or *subset* of organizational nationalism. Finally, *organizational political ideology* is its executives’ or employees’ partisan values of right and wrong, usually along the liberalism-conservatism spectrum (Chin et al., 2013; Gupta et al., 2017; Simons & Ingram, 1997). Nationalistic values often coincide with political ideologies in organizations (Freeden, 1998); politically active executives and employees may be more or less nationalistic (Bonikowski & DiMaggio, 2016; Bonikowski et al., 2021).

Appendix 1
Organizational nationalism and related concepts

Concepts	Definition	Representative Studies	Difference from OGN	Relation to OGN
Organizational Nationalism (OGN)	OGN refers to organizational efforts to actively adopt, embody, and promote the identity and interest of a particular nation.	Yue et al. (2024), Takeda (2025), Yue et al. (in press).		
Economic Nationalism (ECN)	ECN refers the policy-based state intervention to protect domestic industries for broader national objectives.	Bucheli et al. (2023), Bertrand et al. (2016), Nielsen (1979).	• ECN emphasizes economic policies not organizational behaviors.	• ECN creates the conditions for OGN • ECN can result from organizations lobbying the state for protectionist policies.
Techno Nationalism (TCN)	TCN stresses technology as a critical domain for geopolitical competition between nations.	Luo (2022), Luo and Van Assche (2023), Li et al. (2024).	• TCN emphasizes the government's technology policies not organizational behaviors.	• TCN encourages organizations to align R&D and innovation with national agenda, intensifying OGN.
Resource Nationalism (RSN)	RSN refers to the state's intervention in natural resources (e.g., oil, gas, minerals) to protect or enhance its national patrimony and sovereignty.	Click and Weiner (2010), Bucheli and Aguilera (2010).	• RSN focuses on external risks, especially for multinationals, not organizational behaviors.	• RSN can result from domestic organizations' lobbying over the state to disadvantage foreign rivals
Corporate Rhetorical Nationalism (CRN)	CRN describes how businesses use nationalist language in their communications and rhetoric to show that they support national interests and identity.	Yue et al. (2024).	• CRN focuses on nationalistic rhetoric and communications, not other organizational behaviors.	• CRN is one type of OGN • OGN is a broader concept that also includes non-rhetorical aspects organizational behaviors that manifest nationalism.
Nationalist Sentiment (NST)	NST refers to the general level of national pride or chauvinism prevalent among a population.	Yiu et al. (2022), Edman et al. (2024), Dow and Cuypers (2024).	• NST is a societal level phenomenon whereas OGN describes individual organizations' behaviors.	• NST can encourage OGN. • OGN can reinforce NST.
Patriotism (PAT)	PAT refers to a positive attachment and loyalty to one's nation without necessarily involving hostility toward other nations.	Kosterman and Feshbach (1989), Balabanis et al. (2001), Mohr and Schumacher (2019).	• PAT does not view outgroups as threats or inferior.	• Organizational PAT is part of OGN. • Both OGN and PAT stem from national identification.
Populism (POP)	POP refers to a political ideology that claims to represent the common citizen while criticizing established institutions, elites, or political systems.	Blake et al. (2024), Corina et al. (2025).	• POP is a type of political risk for organizations. • POP distinguishes "people" and "elite," not the domestic ingroup and foreign outgroup as in ONG.	• Both OGN and POP are centered on the distinction between an ingroup and an outgroup.
Organizational Political Ideology (OPI)	OPI refers to prevailing beliefs among organizational members about the how the social world operates regarding conservatism versus liberalism	Chin et al. (2013), Gupta et al. (2017).	• OPI focuses on the domestic partisan divisions, especially along the liberal-conservative spectrum • OPI is brought to organizations rather than being shaped by them • OPI research anchors on US firms	• OPI intersects with OGN • In the US, conservative ideology holders define nationhood in more exclusionary and critical terms while liberals endorse more inclusive and positive conceptions

Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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